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THE MAGIC OF THE MOVIES

Exhibitors are confident that the Indian gross box office collections for 2023 will surpass last year's figure

tor Akshaye Rathi, Director of Aashirwad Theatres, adding that it's almost a three-way split now between Hindi, regional languages and Hollywood in some multiplexes. "Earlier, Malayalam, Kannada, Punjabi or Marathi films were only limited to their respective states and did not have a larger piece of the overall national box office pie. But now the Indian box office is gaining more width and depth," says Tushar Dhingra, Founding CEO of Dhishoom Cinemas.

Earlier this year, another Marathi film, *Ved*, earned a brisk ₹61 crore in net Indian box office collection, while 2022's Kannada films *Kantara* (₹300 crore+) and *777 Charlie* (₹84 crore+) earned nearly ₹400 crore at the Indian net box office across the languages they were released in. All these indicate a growing appetite for regional cinema. However, the growth, experts say, is not coming at the cost of Hindi films; instead the overall consumption pie itself is increasing. They point to the successes of Hindi films *Pathaan* and *Gadar 2*, which have become all-time highest grossers after regional cinema became popular in the Hindi belt during the pandemic.

Rathi says this is a result of behavioural patterns changing for everyone during the pandemic. "People

consumed content from Kerala, Andhra, Telangana, Punjab, Bengal, Korea, Japan, Bollywood, Iran and so many other fraternities on streaming platforms... These languages are complementing Hindi cinema and the consumption pie is increasing," he says.

"When you look at a pie chart of 100, regional and Hollywood have increased their share. But in absolute numbers, all three are growing because the overall consumption has increased," adds Cinépolis India's Sampat. Dhishoom's Dhingra puts it like this: If the content is correct, a language-agnostic audience is now available over and above the native speakers.

But, is the overall consumption pie really growing? That will be only known after the total box office col-

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| 29

lections in India are tallied at the end of 2023. Between January and June 2023, the cumulative gross India box office collection for releases stands at ₹4,868 crore. Ormax pegs this to be 15 per cent lower than the same period in 2022. At this rate, 2023 is expected to end at ₹9,736 crore, 8 per cent lower than last year. However, the second half of 2023 has a strong line-up of films that are expected to perform well, especially *Jawan*, *Salaar* and *Tiger 3*. This puts the year in good stead to surpass the 2022 gross box office collections, or at least get very close to them, the Ormax report says.

Pre-pandemic, the record for the best year for the Indian box office was for 2019, with its gross collection of ₹10,948 crore. After the Covid-19 lockdowns severely impacted the revenues of theatres for about two years, the year 2022 saw a rebound, with an annual gross box office collection of ₹10,637 crore, according to Ormax Media's report.

Exhibitors, meanwhile, are confident that the Indian gross box office collection for 2023 will surpass last year's figure. Dhishoom's Dhingra estimates the collection will touch ₹7,000 crore by the end of August and wrap up the year close to ₹11,000 crore. Sampat is more optimistic. He estimates Cinépolis' collections during July-December to be twice what they did during January-June. If that is to be extrapolated to the Indian box office, the collections could touch ₹12,000 crore. **BT**

@SaysVidya